

The Right to Be Forgotten

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Essay

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Growing up in the 1980s and 90s, youthful mistakes, bad fashion choices, and cringeworthy phases faded naturally into the memories of a few witnesses. Today, the permanent digital ledger of social media means every adolescent misstep is recorded, archived, and searchable, destroying the psychological grace of a fresh start.

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Before the days of phones with cameras built in, social media, search engines, or the strange modern need to photograph a sandwich before eating it, anyone could assume that they had some sort of privacy implied. Not legal privacy, necessarily, and certainly not the kind written in small print by attorneys who charge by the comma, but a natural privacy. A human privacy. The privacy that came from the fact that people forgot things.

Some actions or embarrassments were witnessed by family, peer groups, or even the entire student body of your middle school, but that was as far as things went. Whether you slipped on ice, fell out of a tree, asked someone out way above your class, wore a shirt that looked like it had been designed by a committee of colorblind gym teachers, or even did a keg stand in your dorm, there was a finite number of people who would see it. Even fewer would remember it a year or two later.

Those are not the times we live in anymore.

Before digital media, embarrassment had a natural expiration date. It lived in memory, faded with time, and was usually replaced by someone else's unfortunate haircut, public rejection, or cafeteria disaster. Today, however, the internet can preserve even the most ordinary humiliations indefinitely. It can detach them from context, make them searchable, and allow people who were not there, do not know you, and have never had to survive seventh grade with your haircut, to judge you forever.

This raises a question society has not answered very well: do we have the right to outgrow our worst moments?

Since the invention of the smartphone, our lives have become recordable and shareable to the globe within seconds. There are contests, trends, targeted campaigns, reaction videos, stitches, duets, reposts, and whatever new social media verb has been invented by the time this sentence is read. Everything about everyone can be shown to everyone around all of us, whether they asked for it or not.

Social media has taken the simple concept of sharing photos and images to a whole new level. There was a time when sharing photographs required effort, patience, and at least one person in the family who knew where the slide projector was stored.

When a grandparent wanted to show me photos of their trip to the Grand Canyon or Europe, they had a task list to complete. First, they had to get the film developed. Then they had to prepare the slides or have them made. Then they had to put them in order for proper presentation. Then, because apparently vacation photos once required narration, they had to prepare a script explaining each location, who was present, what the weather was like, which cousin was "being difficult," and why a particular rock formation was more impressive in person.

They would set up a presentation with a slide projector and share it with groups of people as an event. Maybe it was vanity. Maybe it was innocent storytelling. Maybe it was an early warning system for children who had not yet learned that "come look at our vacation pictures" meant "you are trapped here until an adult says you may leave."

The telltale sheet hanging on a living room wall told you everything you needed to know. You were in for a long night of keeping your comments, sneers, and eye rolls to yourself in a semi-dark room with family for at least an hour or two. The phrase "only two more reels left" could drain the hope from a room faster than a power outage.

Today, that entire ritual has been compressed into seconds. A photo can be posted before the event has technically ended. Loved ones receive notifications of a random park bench that someone famous may have sat on two decades earlier, paired with the caption, “I can’t believe we got to see this!”

Thankfully, from a mile away or even half the world away, you no longer have to hide your distaste in person. You can open the image on your phone or tablet, see the shared treasure, and comment without making eye contact. You do not have to witness the crushed dreams or hurt feelings when you type, “nice bench,” close the app, and return to whatever more important thing you were doing, such as watching a video of a raccoon stealing cat food.

That example is harmless, mostly. Annoying, yes, but harmless. It illustrates the instantaneous impulse to share everything we do with everyone we know. The older generations had photo albums, slide trays, and the occasional Christmas letter printed on festive stationery. The on-demand generations have permanent feeds, cloud backups, hashtags, and a public record of their lunch.

There have been many jokes, but also many truths, about people posting every meal they eat, every outfit they wear, and the results of their date last night. Society has gone from “some things are best left unsaid” to “why wouldn’t you want to know everything about me?”

But the real problem is not the vacation photo, the sandwich, or the park bench. The real problem begins when the same machinery used to share harmless moments is used to preserve humiliating ones. A family slideshow could bore you, but it usually could not ruin your reputation twelve years later in another state. A photo album stayed on a shelf. A rumor stayed mostly in town. A bad moment had boundaries.

The internet does not respect boundaries.

Imagine your seventh-grade self, growing up in the 1980s or 1990s, sitting in homeroom on one of the last days of the school year. The classroom has no air conditioning, because apparently children of that era were expected to build character by sweating through social studies. The heat begins to rise. Your stomach starts doing somersaults. You know something is wrong, but you are thirteen, so every bodily emergency also has to pass through the committee of shame that lives in your brain.

Before you can raise your hand and ask to be excused to the restroom, your stomach decides to relieve you of its contents onto your desk in front of everyone.

This embarrassment could have happened to any of us. The entire classroom saw it. Someone yelled. Someone laughed. Someone made a sound that was somehow both disgust and delight. By lunch, the story had traveled. By the end of the day, the entire middle school knew. You received nicknames, snickers in the hallway, and possibly a temporary banishment from the ranks of coolness, assuming you had ever been granted a visitor pass to that kingdom in the first place.

But here is the mercy we did not appreciate at the time: by the next school year, most of those classmates would have forgotten the tragedy. They would have moved on to someone else’s braces, someone else’s failed attempt at breakdancing, someone else’s unfortunate gym shorts incident. Your humiliation, while devastating, had a lifespan. It could die a natural death.

Now think of that same incident happening in a classroom of the 2020s.

A photo of the desk or a video of the entire incident could be posted online before the smell hit anyone's nose. The reposts, memes, comments, reaction videos, and private group chats would begin almost immediately. Depending on the cruelty, craftiness, and follower count of the person who posted it, the moment could go viral before the school nurse had even called your mother.

Without thought for your privacy or feelings, your name could be tagged. The location could be identified. The date and time could be embedded. Commentary could be added by people who were not there, did not know you, and could not care less that you were a child having one of the worst days of your life.

Years down the road, when you have finished college, passed certification tests for your field, and are applying for a job, that dreaded photo might come up in a quick search of your name by a human resources manager three states away. It is not a felony charge. It is not a dishonorable discharge. It is not evidence of poor character, professional incompetence, or a secret life as a jewel thief. It is a humiliating childhood moment that should have expired long ago.

And yet there it is.

Who knows what effect that stigma might have? Maybe the hiring manager laughs and moves on. Maybe they wonder about your judgment, even though your only mistake was having a stomach in middle school. Maybe the image becomes a quiet factor in a decision you never get to question. Maybe your great-grandkids will someday find it while doing a family tree project for the third grade, learning that their ancestor survived both adolescence and the early internet, though not with equal dignity.

Do we not have the right for things in our past to be forgotten?

The phrase "the right to be forgotten" can sound legalistic, like something debated in a government building by people wearing suits that cost more than a used Buick. But I mean it first as a moral and social question. Do people have the right to grow? Do children have the right to become adults without every awkward, foolish, embarrassing, or badly dressed moment following them like a digital ghost? Does society have any obligation to let ordinary people change?

Privacy is something that has been steadily taken away from us in the name of technology, convenience, entertainment, and social media. There are platform policies, school rules, state laws, and legal debates around consent, harassment, defamation, and image use, but those do not fully solve the problem. Rules may exist in some places and not in others. Platforms may remove something eventually. A parent may complain. A school may discipline the student who posted it. But once a photo has touched the internet, there is no telling how many times it was downloaded, shared elsewhere, screen-captured, archived, or saved on someone's device locally.

There is no realistic expectation that it can be completely removed from the world's digital memory. Proof of this is easy to find in the nearest person's smartphone image gallery, where there are probably eleven screenshots, three memes, two photos of a parking spot, and a picture of a receipt nobody will ever need.

To be fair, digital records are not always bad. Sometimes they expose cruelty, document abuse, preserve memories, or hold powerful people accountable. There are moments when a camera protects the vulnerable and reveals the truth. Not every act of recording is an act of harm.

But that is exactly why the issue requires judgment. A society that records everything must also learn the difference between accountability and cruelty. There is a difference between documenting wrongdoing and preserving embarrassment for sport. There is a difference between remembering what matters and refusing to let anyone escape who they were at thirteen.

Those of us born in the 1970s and 1980s may be among the last people who truly know what it felt like to make mistakes without creating permanent evidence. We had bad hair, bad clothes, bad judgment, bad music phases, bad yearbook quotes, and bad ideas carried out with great confidence. We were not better than today's young people. In many ways, we were just luckier. Our stupidity often stayed local.

A person could grow up, move away, mature, apologize, change, and become someone else. The past did not disappear entirely, but it softened. It became a story told by an aunt at Thanksgiving, not a search result. It became memory, not metadata.

The right to be forgotten has been taken away from all of us in today's society. The implied privacy that once existed has been extinguished, regardless of rules or regulations put into place. The old decorum of letting an embarrassing moment die has largely left the thought process of a culture trained to capture, post, react, and move on before considering the human being trapped inside the content.

We cannot uninvent the smartphone. We cannot stuff social media back into the cursed bottle it crawled out of. But we can recover some restraint. We can teach children, and maybe remind ourselves, that not everything funny deserves to be posted. Not every mistake needs an audience. Not every humiliation should become a memory owned by strangers.

We have lost the social grace of allowing embarrassment to expire. We should try to get it back.